in the city. However, Srinivas allays the concerns, saying the SPV and the government will ensure that construction does not begin till all environmental and other clearances are secured.

Politics, too, is playing a part. "We all want development," says Aaditya Thackeray, former minister and Sena (UBT) leader. "But should it be the development of Dharavi or that of Adani?" he asked at a recent public meeting. "If the people of Dharavi are not getting homes here, what and who is this redevelopment for?" Talking to INDIA TODAY, the Sena (UBT) leader alleged that the BMC was being denied a premium of Rs 7,500 crore for its land as well as the TDR incentives. The state should have adopted a contractor-based model to redevelop Dharavi, like it had done with the Bombay Development Department (BDD) chawls, he says. Incidentally, residents of the BDD redevelopment in Worli and elsewhere are getting 500 sq. ft flats, and the Sena (UBT) has demanded that Dharavikars get the same.

Dharavi has a strong Dalit and Muslim presence, and has been a Congress stronghold since 1980, barring a small blip around 1995-99. Varsha Gaikwad, the party's MP from Mumbai North Central and a former Dharavi MLA, levels a more serious charge. She fears that since Dharavi is a traditional Congress constituency, there is a chance that Muslims would be resettled outside it to change the demography. "The businesses that are the identity of Dharavi (such as leather and recycling), could (also) be forced out," she alleges. Rajesh Khandare, a Shinde Sena leader, pooh-poohs such allegations. "Around 95 per cent of Dharavi residents stay in 50-100 sq. ft houses. They are not opposed to the project, it is only the large godown owners who are against it," he says. However, he concedes that the lack of transparency about the plans has complicated matters.



"The redevelopment is a land grab in disguise. Some people will get houses, but what about jobs? Should they sit outside the houses and beg?"

—KARUNANIDHI KANNAN, *Kamalanagar businessman*

Opposition to the redevelopment is the highest in the Sanaullah compound area, said to be India's largest recycling hub. S. Selvan, a member of the Dharavi Businessmen Welfare Association, says the area has 10,000 godowns. He says the "circular economy" of the recycling industry, including the rag pickers, kabadi shops and others, would be hit badly if these units were forced to shift. "We pay GST to the government, and even their revenues will be hit if Dharavi's businesses are displaced," warns Selvan. Stakeholders of the Rs 200 crore leather industry are also feeling pressured. They say the anti-meat vigilantism, the flood of artificial leather and cheaper Chinese imports have already put the sector on the back foot. Any displacement from Dharavi may sound the death knell for their businesses, he warns.

Srinivas admits that most businesses being in the informal sector is a big hurdle, for it means a "low-level investment trap as most of the people lack entitlements". Once the new Dharavi comes up, they will be part of the formal sector, says the officer. Commercial units in the redeveloped Dharavi will get state GST refunds for the first five years, he points out. Critics say that while conventional SRA projects need consent from 51 per cent of residents to appoint a developer, this clause was done away with in Dharavi. As justification, Srinivas says that "since the developer has been appointed by the government, consent is there". CM Fadnavis has also given assurances that

INTERVIEW

"The objective is proper housing for all"

S.V.R. Srinivas, CEO, Dharavi Redevelopment Project (DRP), talks about project deadlines, resettlement of slum-dwellers and the attendant controversies. Edited excerpts:

On the 'new' Dharavi: Dharavi should look like a modern town, no gentrification and ghettoisation, with access to amenities for all. It will be a formalised, thriving, much-larger economy than even before. It will also be a huge step towards a slum-free Mumbai.

On the rehabilitation project timelines: Construction could begin in 2-3 months. The project should be completed within seven years from issue of first commencement certificate (CC). Of course, it'll be extremely challenging....

On private agencies being involved in the household surveys in Dharavi: The household surveys are conducted by agencies, but our officers are present at every step. They sign the document as well as the receipt. The agencies